Bo 5785

The ספר אור גדליהו, by רב גדליה שור זצ"ל, is a wonderful ספר. Every time it's reprinted, it sells out almost immediately, and there's a good reason for that - it's a truly enlightening set of ספרים. On פרשת בא, the אור גדליהו writes that every מצוה has an integral and significant component: זכר ליציאת מצרים. We often say these words without understanding their depth because we're so accustomed to them. It doesn't just mean a remembrance of יציאת מצרים. According to רב גדליה, performing a מצוה allows a person to be בפועל זוכה - in an actual, physical sense - to the same inspiration and enlightenment that was experienced at יציאת מצרים, the אור שהיה בעת יציאת מצרים. This is an essential part of doing a מצוה.

This concept is intriguing. We recently experienced it during חנוכה, and since I'm recording this just after חנוכה, it's fresh in my mind. The אור הגנוז, the hidden light created during ששת ימי בראשית, is reserved for the צדיקים in העולם הבא. Yet, a portion of this light is present in the חנוכה candles. When we light the נרות, we infuse them with the אור הגנוז, which is generated by the ברכה we make. This light, although invisible to us, carries a special קדושה. While we may not see it, many גדולים have perceived this hidden כח in the candles.

Similarly, each מצוה we perform contains within it a similar כח. רב גדליה brings a רְאָיָה from the גר"א that the spiritual experience of יציאת מצרים is embedded in every מצוה. The גר"א, in his ספר אדרת אליהו, explains this using a פסוק in האזינו (32:11): כְּנֶשֶׁר יָעִיר קִנּוֹ עַל גּוֹזָלָיו יְרַחֵף - like an eagle who spreads his wings over his little eagles, the little babies; יִפְרֹשׂ כְּנָפָיו יִקָּחֵהוּ יִשָּׂאֵהוּ עַל אֶבְרָתוֹ. The גר"א discusses four מצוות which are represented by this פסוק: 1) מזוזה, 2) ציצית, 3) תפילין של ראש, and 4) תפילין של יד, all of which surround and protect us, offering a glimpse of התגלות השכינה. רב גדליה emphasizes that this גילוי שכינה is present in all מצוות, not just these four.

A fascinating insight into a particular part of a מצוה comes from the ספר אפיריון, written the בעל קיצור שולחן ערוך, R' Shlomo Ganzfried. He says in this week's פרשה (12:39): וַיֹּאפוּ אֶת הַבָּצֵק - they baked the dough; עֻגֹת מַצָּה זוֹ שֶׁאָנוּ אוֹכְלִים, עַל שׁוּם מַה? עַל שׁוּם שֶׁלֹּא הִסְפִּיק הגדה של פסח: מַצּוֹת כִּי לֹא חָמֵץ כִּי גֹרְשׁוּ מִמִּצְרַיִם. We say in the מצה זו שאנו אוכלים, על שום מה? על שום שלא הספיק בְּצֵקָם שֶׁל אֲבוֹתֵינוּ לְהַחֲמִיץ - Why are we eating this מצה? We're eating this מצה because of the מצה that they ate in מצרים, which they did in a big, fast hurry, and didn't have enough time for it to become חמץ.

The רמב"ם notes that מצה made with מי פירות (fruit juice) doesn't become חמץ, as it lacks the ability to ferment. However, certain liquids - wine, oil, honey, and milk - are not used because they don't meet the criteria of לחם עוני. Despite this, מצה made with these liquids won't become חמץ, and one could still fulfill the מצוה with it.

The ספר אפיריון questions why we insist on using water, which can cause חמץ, requiring meticulous care - such as using מים שלנו and adhering to strict time limits? Why not use מי פירות, which pose no חמץ risk? The answer is: because that's how they did it in מצרים. Therefore, that's what the זכר ליציאת מצרים is when it comes to this particular aspect of making מצה. We דוקא use מים because if you would use מי פירות, there would be no זכר, because that's not the way they did it. So in the הגדה we ask מצה זו שאנו אוכלים על שום מה - Why are we eating מצה made in this particular difficult way, using water? It would have been much better to do it without any problem of חמץ? עַל שׁוּם שֶׁלֹּא הִסְפִּיק - Because that's the way they did it in מצרים, and if we follow in their footsteps, we will be זוכה to the same גילוי שכינה, to the same elevation in our spiritual status, that they had in מצרים.

What a gigantic חידוש! No matter how poor our מצוה observance is, the key is to do the מצוות in the proper way, which is the way that our פריערדיקע דורות did them. By doing the מצוות this way, we'll continue the מסורה, elevate ourselves in רוחניות, do the רצון השם, and bring גאולה to the world.

https://youtu.be/nmAVe_u23o4